

Is using AI chatbots really as much of an environmental disaster as people claim?

Posted by u/ferriemathew • 0 points • 33 comments

I'm in a debate with a friend where they claim that me using chatGPT to refine my ideas contributes to humanitarian disasters where people have no access to clean water because it's all being used for data centers. I claim that I'm only one user so my impact is negligible, and besides it's too useful of a tool to stop using.

What are the community's thoughts?

Comments

u/Sharizay • 1 points • 2025-12-10 19:43 UTC

Why is no one answering the question? Instead, they (the responses) seem to immediately jump to things like what else is bad for the environment, why people say it's bad, server farms are already being built so why bother, that what we (as individuals) do doesn't matter (which is quite the point, isn't it? That giant corporations are using the bots and it is they who are destroying the environment? I mean, we don't have a choice as to whether a company uses bots when we contact customer service, right?)

Just my opinion, but using "AI" to improve your business is not "cheating," but why not trust yourself and the humans around you? Why surrender to so-called "AI?" (So-called because what is currently out there is not even close to any kind of artificial intelligence.)

So then, without giving a million other ways that fresh water is used, do server farms use an inordinate amount of fresh water? Yes.

u/Zombiespire • 2 points • 2025-08-29 17:10 UTC

Anyone who cares about the environment should be loudly advocating for Nuclear Energy. If they don't, it's empty virtue signaling and I couldn't care less what they think about AI

u/SummerEchoes • 2 points • 2025-08-29 00:30 UTC

Actually using an LLM is about three Google Searches worth of electricity, not that much.

The training is another thing but it's hard to measure because we don't know how long each model will be used for.

YouTube uses about 10X the amount of energy per use.

u/Anal-Y-Sis • 2 points • 2025-08-28 07:46 UTC

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The overlap between anti-AI people and vegans/vegetarians who choose almond milk over cow milk is pretty huge, and almond farming uses more water than data centers. It isn't even close. It takes about 1.1 gallons of water ***per almond*** to grow.

>Edit: also, is using generative AI to refine and organize your original ideas into something that makes more sense considered cheating?

No more so than using the paint bucket tool in Photoshop to fill a selected area.

u/LogicalWeird6249 • 1 points • 2026-02-05 12:36 UTC

[https://preview.redd.it/6pwqlzhu7ohg1.jpeg?
width=960&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=d7f7c66768e90aa2c8ff84a02795657dbcdbea1](https://preview.redd.it/6pwqlzhu7ohg1.jpeg?width=960&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=d7f7c66768e90aa2c8ff84a02795657dbcdbea1)

u/Calm-Present-8038 • 2 points • 2025-08-27 19:52 UTC

Not anymore than anything else we use that requires electricity. All of the shit that requires electricity damages our environment.

Are people gonna give up tv? Computers? Phones? Cars? Lights?

I highly doubt it lol

u/D-I-L-F • 2 points • 2025-08-26 08:32 UTC

People claim everything is an environmental disaster. The truth of the matter is that unless you're the ceo of a massive company, or a big figure in the government, what you do doesn't affect the environment.

u/AmazonSeller2016 • 2 points • 2025-08-25 21:30 UTC

I use urine for critter repellent, composting, and fertilizing - that's a flush or two a day I'm saving, so I'm using ChatGPT guilt free 😊

u/PerspectiveThick458 • 2 points • 2025-08-25 19:24 UTC

not anymore than you using facebook , Tictock or binge watching netflex .All runs on the same type infrustructure

u/beeting • 3 points • 2025-08-25 16:34 UTC

Here, win your argument: <https://andymasley.substack.com/p/a-cheat-sheet-for-conversations-about>

u/CommodoreGirlfriend • 3 points • 2025-08-25 16:17 UTC

No, it's a horseshit argument that they used to say about video games

u/Sesquatchhegyi • 3 points • 2025-08-25 15:39 UTC

We had a similar discussion with my friend.

Let's say - as others wrote here - that one prompt equals 5 drops of water and one second of microwave usage.

I asked him how many times he takes a shower a week. He takes daily showers. Now if he just uses

his shower a second more every day, he will use an extra 0.1-0.2 liters of hot water, which "wastes" more water and energy than 400 queries, each day.

Somehow, we are not worried about showering an extra 1 second each day, but we are told to feel guilty for running a few extra queries a day.

u/Antiantiai • 1 points • 2025-08-28 16:36 UTC

The scope of scale is what they are missing. Because to those who are anti-ai ***any*** amount is too much. So they really are flipping their shit over ***drops*** of water getting used.

u/Glittering-Heart6762 • 3 points • 2025-08-25 15:27 UTC

No more than playing your favorite online game

u/ferriemattthew • 1 points • 2025-08-25 15:28 UTC

Better yet if chatbots are so bad we might as well shut down the entire internet

u/Moth_LovesLamp • 2 points • 2025-08-25 15:20 UTC

big enough that is starting to impact local communities, strain water resources small town power grids, not big enough for the general populace to care. As long it fills it's purpose, brings entertainment and money people will overlook environmental impact until it's too late.

u/ferriemattthew • 1 points • 2025-08-25 15:24 UTC

I guess with any luck, people switching from cloud-based services to self hosting might at least slow that disaster.

u/DumboVanBeethoven • 3 points • 2025-08-25 15:19 UTC

Trump is waging war on the environment right now and you're worried about this? He's literally fighting against windmills!

u/ferriemattthew • 2 points • 2025-08-25 15:20 UTC

I'm not worried, lmao, the other person is.

u/Torchiest • 3 points • 2025-08-25 15:09 UTC

No. Prices help us decided how to use our resources. If ChatGPT is using "too much" energy, it will eventually have to charge more to make up the difference. This will make people use it less and save energy. The other, not mutually exclusive possibility is that energy becomes more expensive, so we start making more of it to make up the difference.

u/JealousGanache23 • 4 points • 2025-08-25 15:04 UTC

Crypto, YouTube, Netflix, any streaming service is worse.